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Sexual solidarity and the secrets of sight and sound

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sexual solidarity and the secrets of sight and sound

Cemaasiit combines secret knowledge of sight *and* sound. In its usual sense, *cemaasiit* means a wild creature, a monster, an unknown being usually found in the forest. In Okiek tales, *cemaasiit* is also an ogre who tricks people and then eats them. The secret *cemaasiit* of initiation is aural throughout most of the initiation. Late at night during each of the ceremonies, the eerie roar of *cemaasiit* is heard approaching or inside the house of seclusion. Initiates are told it is coming to eat them.

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Cemaasiit remains hidden, held back and present only in its threatening roar, until initiation is virtually complete. It is revealed at the final secret ceremony of coming out, at last removing the remaining distinction of ritual knowledge between initiates and adult women. When each initiate sees, holds, and herself produces the roar of *cemaasiit*, the shared experience of secrets that is the basis of sexual equality and solidarity within the ritual community is complete. A final climax to the ceremonies of seclusion, all secrets are at last shared as initiates reach the juncture of adulthood, leaving the world of seclusion with people of their own sex to reenter ordinary daily life in their new status.

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Cemaasiit is a most appropriate finale to the constitution of new adults not only because it combines secrets of sight and sound, but because it carries other associations and double-entendres that play on its name as well. During seclusion, initiates paint themselves daily with white clay and charcoal until

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Gender relations created through differing daily experiences, decisions, and possibilities become an ontology of gender through initiation. Inequalities and contradictions in those relations and their justifications may well be recognized and/or expressed in various ways. Rooted  460 as they are in what seems the intrinsic essence of human experience, however, the relations are difficult to question radically or alter significantly, particularly when the same basic patterns of social organization persist and are adapted to changing circumstances.

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